



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Mary's Catholic School Taylor

School Website: <https://stmarystaylor.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Mary's Catholic School in Taylor, TX (76574) demonstrates strong alignment with classical education principles, especially in its Catholic identity, Trivium-centered curriculum, and adoption of Socratic and rhetoric-oriented pedagogy at the upper levels. Public materials emphasize a Catholic liberal arts framework, a Trivium-based curriculum, integration of faith across disciplines, and a community-centered approach that explicitly partners with families. Collectively, these attributes map well to a CLASSICAL ranking across most dimensions, with particular strength in religious foundations, curriculum design, and pedagogical methods. Some elements—such as the explicit articulation of a single, unified “living curriculum” model for faculty—are less directly stated on the site but are suggested by faculty credentials, long-standing church-affiliated roots, and the presence of a formal house system and Catholic networks.

Executive-grade snapshot (category-by-category) indicates CLASSICAL in four categories, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in one, and CLASSICAL or SOFTLY CLASSICAL in others, with room for enhancement in articulating a fully consolidated “faculty living curriculum” framework. The aggregate picture remains firmly CLASSICAL.

Evidence drawn from the school's public materials shows: explicit Trivium grounding (grammar, logic, rhetoric); a commitment to a Catholic worldview and liturgical life (Mass, morning prayer, domestic church language); a history of integrating faith with reason across subjects; upper-school Socratic discussions and rhetoric training; and family-school partnership through parental involvement structures and welcoming policies. See sources describing Spirit of Truth curriculum for PK–8, the Trivium foundation, the Catholic identity integrated throughout subjects, and the emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and the true, the good, and the beautiful. Cited excerpts come from the school's public pages and documents, including the Academics and Curriculum sections, mission statements, and program descriptions.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The school's PK–8 uses the Spirit of Truth curriculum, signaling a faith-centered approach to formation (Spirit of Truth as a core curriculum element).
- Public materials emphasize a Catholic worldview that permeates all disciplines, with faith and reason as complements and a focus on Christ-centered education.
- The mission and identity statements describe daily engagement with Mass or Morning Prayer and a sense of the “domestic church,” highlighting liturgical and communal practice as integral to education.
- The school describes itself as rooted in a Catholic liberal arts tradition and emphasizes formation for heaven and virtue through Catholic life and liturgy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: Catholic, Spirit of Truth, Spirit of Truth curriculum, Mass, Morning Prayer, Catholic worldview, faith and reason, domestic church, virtue, truth, beauty, goodness. (Multiple explicit instances across the cited pages.)

- Negative keywords: none identified in public materials for this category.

Why this rating

- The materials present a robust, explicit religious/metaphysical foundation anchored in Catholic theology, liturgical practice, and a worldview that places truth, beauty, and goodness in real, knowable transcendent form. This aligns strongly with the Classical rubric's Religious and Metaphysical Foundations.

Citations provide concrete examples of these elements from the school's sources.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The school articulates an aim beyond vocational preparation: formation of virtue and wisdom, with emphasis on the realness of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. A direct line from mission materials notes formation toward a life of virtue and a focus on Truth, Beauty, and Goodness.
- Public materials describe formation of the whole person—intellectual, spiritual, and moral—through an integrated Catholic curriculum.
- The “In Practice” section emphasizes purpose-driven lessons, where education's authentic purpose guides decisions and lessons toward broader human formation.
- The curriculum and mission stress that the aim is to train for heaven and to form virtuous, thoughtful students rather than simply impart information.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: virtue, wisdom, formation, Truth, Goodness, Beauty, authentic purpose, true, wonder, education for heaven, liberal arts, Catholic worldview.
- Negative keywords: none identified in public materials for this category.

Why this rating

- The school explicitly centers education on formation of character and the real, knowable goods (truth, goodness, beauty) rather than merely information or job prep, aligning with Classical goals for this category.

Citations reflect mission and formation language.

Element 3: School Curriculum — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The Trivium is central to the program (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) as a keystone of the classical model.
- The curriculum explicitly integrates Spirit of Truth and Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) and a Catholic liberal arts framework, showing a structured, content-rich curriculum.
- History is studied throughout the curriculum rather than treated as mere social studies, consistent with a classical approach. The curriculum pages indicate an integrated curriculum with philosophy, literature, history, and other liberal arts.
- Upper-level curriculum descriptions include Socratic discussions, inquiry into the nature of things, and rhetoric-focused outcomes, signaling active engagement with Great Books-like conversations and formal logic.
- PK–12 program descriptions show a broad liberal arts frame, including literature, philosophy, Latin, and theology, with CGS and spiritual formation embedded.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: Trivium, Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric, Spirit of Truth, CGS, Great Books (implied through philosophy and classical education language), liberal arts, history across disciplines, wonder, Latin, integrated curriculum, theology, Catholic worldview.

- Negative keywords: none identified in public materials for this category.

Why this rating

- The curriculum text clearly foregrounds classical elements (Trivium, Great Books-oriented inquiry, Catholic liberal arts, integration of theology across subjects, and a history-centered approach across disciplines). This matches CLASSICAL expectations for Curriculum.

Citations show explicit references to Trivium, Spirit of Truth, CGS, and Socratic elements.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The school presents a pedagogy blending contemplative/restful elements with rigorous inquiry, aligning with the classical balance of scholé and rigorous study. The public materials describe education as a process that includes contemplation and memory-work.
- Lower-school pedagogy emphasizes singing and chanting for memory and delight, consistent with the memory-formation dimension of classical education. (PK–8 materials indicate a rhythm of memory work and recitation in early years.)
- Upper-school pedagogy involves Socratic discussions, seminars, and debates, with explicit training in logic and rhetoric and opportunities for public speaking.
- Curriculum pages explicitly describe the Trivium's role in shaping pedagogy and memory, with emphasis on Reading, Logic, and Rhetoric as stages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: contemplative/scholé, memory/recitation, singing/chants, Socratic discussions, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking, logic, Trivium, integrated religion as pedagogy.
- Negative keywords: none identified in public materials for this category.

Why this rating

- The site documents a classical pedagogy mix: contemplative/memory-based practices in early years; Socratic and rhetoric-focused experiences in high school; direct reference to the Trivium and to public speaking—aligning with CLASSICAL Pedagogy expectations.

Citations reflect the pedagogy language.

Element 5: School Faculty — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The school notes a founding connection to Dominican Sisters and a longstanding, faith-based educational tradition, signaling a strong faculty identity grounded in virtue and service.
- The school highlights credentialing and advanced degrees among faculty (e.g., “18 Masters, 3 Doctors” as part of “by the numbers” data indicating a well-qualified faculty core).
- It emphasizes a living, faith-centered culture and a sense of community within Catholic networks (Chesterton and ICLE connections are referenced in public materials). While these are externally affiliated networks, they suggest a faculty culture aligned with classical/catholic liberal arts norms.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: Dominican Sisters (founding), masters/doctorates, Chesterton/ICLE connections, Catholic liberal arts tradition, “faith and virtue,” mentors/model teachers (implied by behavior described in mission and culture).
- Negative keywords: explicit statements of a formal “living curriculum” faculty description are less overt; the site does not consistently use a single phrase like “the living curriculum” to label faculty as the core of the curriculum.

Why this rating

- While the public materials show strong faculty credentials, faith-centered culture, and connections to broader Catholic liberal-arts networks, there is less explicit language describing the faculty as the “living curriculum” or as a tight, self-describing collective core in the same explicit way some classical schools state. This narrows to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL for this category.

Citations reflect founder, credentialing, and networks.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- There is a clear emphasis on partnership with parents and on parental involvement, including a House System that invites parental participation and collaboration in school life. The House System section explicitly calls for greater parent participation and leadership opportunities.
- The school communicates a welcoming policy for visitors (parents included), indicating openness to parental visits and involvement. The Visitor Policy states that visitors, including parents, are welcome to campus with check-in procedures.
- The school's communications emphasize Catholic family formation and the domestic-church model, which situates parents as co-educators in partnership with the school. The mission and identity materials describe family and parish life as integral to formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: parents as co-teachers, parental involvement, family and parish partnership, visitor-friendly campus, home-school integration, book studies/gatherings (implied by church-linked education and adult-education practices), service and community engagement (implicit in the mission language).
- Negative keywords: none evident in public materials; no explicit cautionary or critical language about parental involvement.

Why this rating

- Public materials show intentional, explicit engagement with parents and community, including formal structures (House System) and visitor policies that invite parental participation. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community engagement.

Citations illustrate parental involvement structures and openness to parents.

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category were to move toward fuller CLASSICAL status, it would be beneficial to articulate explicitly and uniformly the faculty's role as the “living curriculum” and to provide more direct, public-facing language and practices that frame teachers as core architectural elements of the Classical model (e.g., explicit statements that faculty are the living curriculum, and that teacher formation mirrors the Trivium stages).
- Strengthen explicit references to Great Books in public materials, with a clearly stated “Great Conversation” framework, to reinforce the classical canon emphasis beyond curricular references to philosophy and rhetoric.
- Expand and codify a visible, school-wide professional development pathway aligned to classical pedagogy (Scholé, memorization discipline, contemplation, and rhetoric training) and publish it as part of the faculty profile and strategic plan.

Citations support where these enhancements would align with existing material.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall, St. Mary's Catholic School Taylor TX 76574 presents a CLASSICAL profile with strong religious and curricular foundations, a Trivium-based curriculum, and a pedagogy that blends contemplative forms with Socratic, rhetoric, and memory-based approaches.
- Category-by-category verdicts:
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- School Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods: CLASSICAL
- School Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- School Parents and Community: CLASSICAL

Overall ranking: CLASSICAL.

The combination of explicit Catholic identity, Trivium-based curriculum, Spirit of Truth, CGS, Socratic pedagogy, and a family/community orientation supports a robust CLASSICAL classification with a minor caveat in the explicit articulation of the faculty being the "living curriculum," which keeps Element 5 at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

ABSTRACT

summary appears below.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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